

EVERYDAY MILLIONAIRES

Ted and Diane admit they were completely broke when they got married. They each brought a pile of student-loan debt into the marriage, and neither had a strong financial background. However, they had something that made all the difference in the world: each other. From the start of their married life, they sat down at the kitchen table with a basic paper budget, doing their best to live on less than they made and attack their debt. “Our starting salaries . . . weren’t great,” Ted said, “but we thought it was more money than we’d ever seen.” After years of living as broke college and grad students, they didn’t let their new incomes go to their heads. Instead, they were intentional about maximizing every dollar. First, they saved up an emergency fund—something they maintain to this day. Then, they declared war on their student loans, throwing every dollar they could at them. They decided to delay the purchase of their first home until the loans were paid off because they didn’t want any distractions. “We avoided ‘stuffitis’ [and] practiced delayed gratification,” they said. When the student loans were paid off, the couple purchased a home and started investing 15% of their income into retirement accounts. They worked together every step of the way, and neither ran ahead of the other. They wanted to win as a team—and they did.

Today, Ted and Diane are in their mid-forties. They just recently paid off their fifteen-year mortgage on their \$300,000 home, they have college savings accounts for their kids’ upcoming college expenses, and they have more than \$1 million in retirement accounts. With all those things taken care of, and with at least twenty years to go before retirement, Ted and Diane are sitting pretty. Ted said, “We have piled up our plunder, and now we are going to live a life full of options while maintaining our commitment to giving to the church and others.” The budget was the cornerstone of Ted and Diane’s financial plan from day one, and that hasn’t changed now that they’ve hit the millionaire mark—and they say it never will.

There are a million other things I could say about budgeting, but I’ll leave those to other books and authors. If budgeting is new to you, though, I strongly suggest two things. First, pick up a copy of Dave Ramsey’s *The Total Money Makeover*. It’s the best book out there on taking control of your money and getting on a plan to beat debt. Second, check out the free budgeting tool called EveryDollar. The website and mobile apps are great, and it’s an easy way to build and track a budget with just a few clicks.